



The Penny Question

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

The article, marked for rhetorical devices (one color throughout):

1 The United States Mint has reported for years that the one-cent coin costs more to make than it is worth. A penny buys nothing on its own, yet it now costs more than a penny to strike and ship, lately closer to three cents than to one. [Antithesis] The figure has stayed above face value every year since 2006. The nickel fails the same test, costing the Mint more than five cents to put a five-cent coin into circulation. Per coin the loss is trivial. In aggregate it is not, because the coins are made by the billions.

2 Other countries have already run the experiment. In its 2012 budget the Canadian government announced it would stop making the penny, and the Royal Canadian Mint ended distribution the following February. Cash purchases in Canada are now rounded to the nearest five cents, while electronic payments, which cost nothing to round, still settle to the exact cent. Australia withdrew its one and two-cent coins decades earlier. None of these governments has moved to bring the small coin back.

3 The case for keeping the penny is not empty. Rounding falls only on cash, which is used more by people with the least, so a price rounded up at the register is a small tax on exactly those buyers. [Concession] Pennies still fill charity jars and school fundraisers. And a currency carries habits and attachments that a balance sheet does not record; the one-cent coin has worn Lincoln's profile since 1909.

4 The evidence has not been kind to that case. Studies of cash transactions have found that rounding to the nearest five cents nets out close to zero for buyers over time, because prices round down about as often as they round up. [Anecdotal vs statistical evidence] Electronic payment, now most of retail, is untouched either way. The charities that once counted pennies increasingly ask for a card instead. The coin has become a rounding error in the economy it was built to serve. [Metaphor]

5 What keeps it in circulation is mostly inertia. Ending the penny would take an act of Congress, which has not come, while the Mint goes on striking a coin it loses money on and a lobbying group funded in part by the zinc that goes into the blanks argues for keeping it. In Ottawa, the missing coin has not been missed. [Understatement / litotes] The American penny stays in production, by default rather than decision.

Devices, and why they are here:

Antithesis (paragraph 1): “A penny buys nothing on its own, yet it now costs more than a penny to strike and ship, lately closer to three cents than to one.”

Setting the coin's worth against its cost in one balanced line (worth a penny, costs nearly three) states the whole problem before any argument begins. The two facts are opposed and weighted evenly, which is antithesis, not irony: there is no gap here between what is said and what is meant, only two true figures pushed against each other.

Concession (paragraph 3): “Rounding falls only on cash, which is used more by people with the least, so a price rounded up at the register is a small tax on exactly those buyers.”

The writer grants the strongest case for keeping the penny in full and in good faith: rounding lands on cash, and cash is used most by those with the least. Conceding this plainly, before answering it, is what lets the later turn read as fair rather than as a thumb on the scale. Tag the granted claim itself, not any signal word.

Anecdotal vs statistical evidence (paragraph 4): “Studies of cash transactions have found that rounding to the nearest five cents nets out close to zero for buyers over time, because prices round down about as often as they round up.”

To answer the concession the writer reaches for statistical evidence, studies of many transactions, rather than a single hard-luck story. The choice of evidence type is deliberate: a number drawn from many cases rebuts a worry about fairness more convincingly than one anecdote could, and it holds the register's sourced, disinterested tone.

Metaphor (paragraph 4): “The coin has become a rounding error in the economy it was built to serve.” Calling the penny a rounding error in the economy it was built to serve turns an abstract claim about irrelevance into a single concrete figure of speech. It is a metaphor, an implied identity with no like or as, and it carries the piece's verdict in a handful of words without the writer stating an opinion.

Understatement / litotes (paragraph 5): “In Ottawa, the missing coin has not been missed.”

In Ottawa, the missing coin has not been missed says far less than it means. The dry understatement, and the quiet play on missing and missed, lets the phrasing carry the judgment that Canada lost nothing, which lands harder than an outright claim would in a register that prizes restraint.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. The relationship between the third paragraph and the fourth is best described as one in which the writer first
 - A) grants the strongest case for keeping the penny, then turns the evidence against it
 - B) raises the main objections to the penny, then concedes that they are valid
 - C) states a personal preference for the penny, then supports it with statistics
 - D) presents two competing studies, then explains why their findings conflict
2. In context, the final sentence ('The American penny stays in production, by default rather than decision') primarily serves to
 - A) frame the penny's survival as the result of inaction rather than deliberate choice
 - B) predict that Congress will vote to eliminate the coin in the near future
 - C) credit lawmakers with deliberately preserving a familiar tradition
 - D) concede that the penny still serves a genuine practical purpose

Multiple choice answer key:

1. Answer A. Paragraph 3 makes the best case for keeping the penny (rounding as a tax on cash buyers, sentiment, charity); paragraph 4 opens with 'The evidence has not been kind to that case' and answers it with data. That is concession followed by an evidence-driven turn. B inverts which side paragraph 3 takes; C imports a personal preference the disinterested register never states; D invents conflicting studies the passage does not contain.

2. Answer A. The close caps a paragraph about inertia (no act of Congress, the Mint striking at a loss, lobbying) and names the cause of the penny's survival as default, not decision. B imports a prediction the text does not make; C inverts the dry, critical tone into praise; D contradicts paragraph 4, which shows the practical case has failed.

Discussion questions:

1. The writer never says outright that the penny should be abolished, yet most readers finish the piece thinking it should. How does building the case almost entirely from costs, precedents, and figures, rather than from open argument, shape the way the conclusion lands?
2. Paragraph 3 spends its length making the best case for keeping the penny before paragraph 4 answers it. What does the writer gain by stating the opposing case fairly, and at length, first?

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. A strong answer notes that by withholding an explicit 'should,' the writer makes the conclusion feel discovered rather than argued. The named body (the Mint), the dated figures (above face value since 2006), and the foreign precedent (Canada) do the persuading, so the reader reaches the verdict and credits it to the evidence rather than to the writer's opinion. The restraint is the persuasion.
2. By granting that rounding can fall hardest on cash users and that the coin carries real attachment, the writer removes the easy charge of bias. Having been fair to the other side, the statistical turn in paragraph 4 reads as a correction of the record rather than a partisan jab, which makes it much harder to wave away.

Writing prompt (homework or extended in-class, Q2 rhetorical analysis):

Read the opener closely and write an essay analyzing the rhetorical choices the writer makes to build a case against the penny while appearing only to report on it. Consider the writer's use of attribution, figures, concession, and tone.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- Students may call the contrast in paragraph 1 (a coin worth one cent that costs nearly three to make) irony. It is closer to antithesis: two opposed facts set in balanced form. Reserve irony for a gap between what is said and what is meant.
- Students often read paragraph 3 as the writer's real position because it argues for the penny. It is a concession: the writer grants the opposing case in good faith in order to answer it in paragraph 4, not to endorse it.
- Students may treat 'the coin has become a rounding error' as a literal accounting term. In context it is a metaphor for irrelevance: the penny now matters about as little as a sum too small to bother counting.
- Students may credit the closing line's force to strong opinion words. It has none; its edge comes from understatement ('by default rather than decision'), which lets the dry phrasing carry the verdict.

AP exam alignment:

Q2 rhetorical-analysis value: a clean model of persuasion by restraint, where attribution, dated figures, and a fairly stated concession do the arguing in place of overt opinion. Good for teaching antithesis versus irony, a concession that precedes a turn, the deliberate choice of statistical over anecdotal evidence, and how understatement can carry a verdict.